

The Savanna



THE DRY, GRASSY PLAINS of the savanna provide food for a variety of seed- and insect-eating birds. Some of these birds depend on the mammals of the grasslands for their food. Oxpeckers, for instance, cling to giraffes, zebras, rhinos, and other animals with their sharp claws and snap up their ticks and other blood-sucking parasites. Vultures and marabou storks help clean up the carcasses left by lions and other big cats.

In some parts of the savanna, trees, such as the flat-topped acacias, can be used as nest sites by birds such as weavers, starlings, or rollers. Other small birds hide their nests on the ground. The savanna has a wet season and a dry season. Birds tend to raise their young after the rains, when the grasses are green and lush and there is plenty of food. Savanna bird life is increasingly threatened by people who live on and farm the remaining grasslands.

Common ostrich
(*Struthio camelus*)
Length: 9 ft 1 in (2 m 75 cm)
Height: up to 9 ft 2 in (2 m 80 cm)



Common ostrich
The ostrich is the largest and tallest bird alive today. It strides effortlessly across the savanna searching for leaves, seeds, and insects with its sharp eyes. The male makes a nest by scraping a hollow in the ground. Several females lay their eggs in one nest.

Secretary bird

This bird was so named because its crest makes it look like an old-fashioned secretary with a quill pen stuck behind its ear. It feeds on small mammals, insects, and some birds and their eggs. It can also kill snakes. The secretary bird snaps up small animals in its sharp bill but kills larger ones by stamping on them. During courtship, the birds fly up high making strange calls. The nest is a platform of sticks, which is built in the top of a tree.



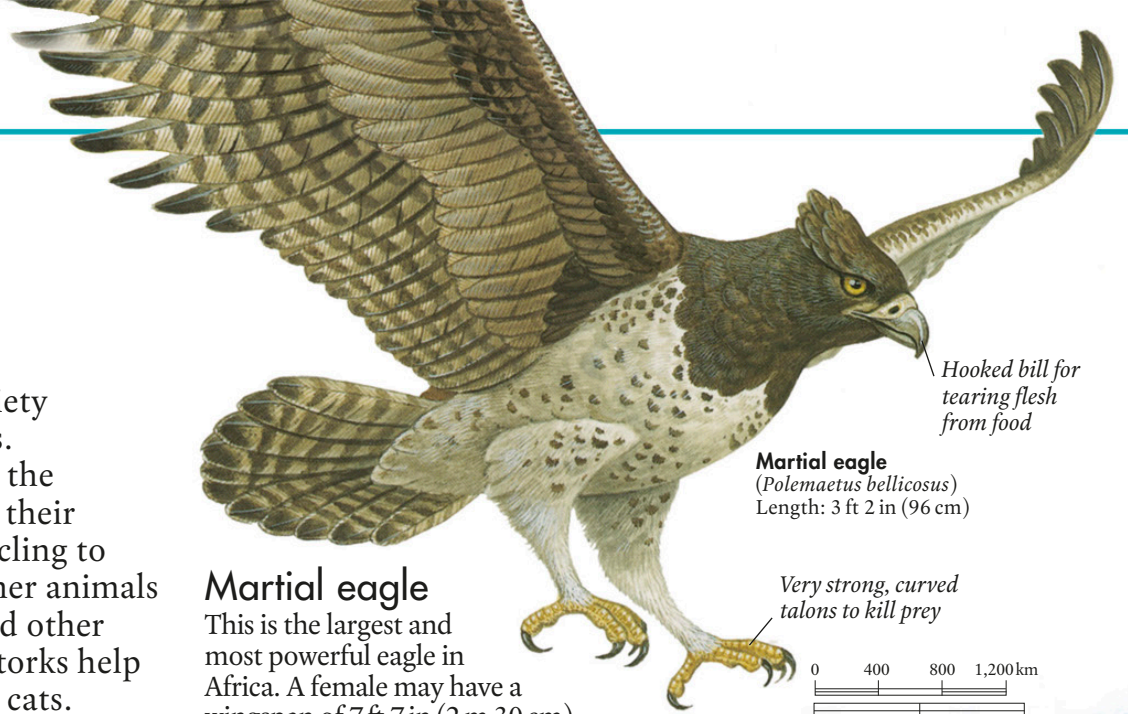
The head crest is often raised while the bird is hunting.

Ostriches are the only birds with two toes on each foot.

Strong legs and toes, enable it to run at up to 43 mph (70 kph).

Secretary bird
(*Sagittarius serpentarius*)
Length: 5 ft (1 m 50 cm)

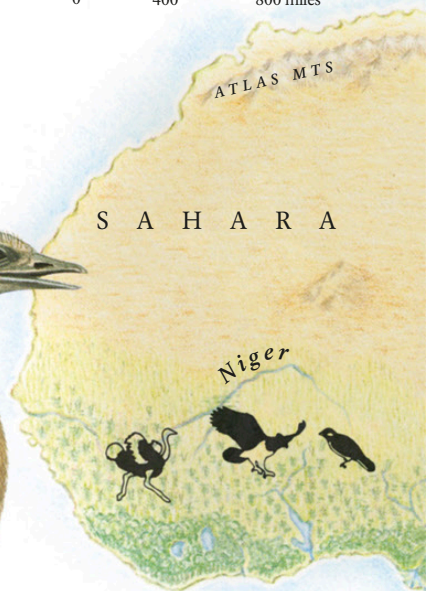
Long legs enable it to walk easily through the tall grasses.



Martial eagle
(*Polemaetus bellicosus*)
Length: 3 ft 2 in (96 cm)

Very strong, curved talons to kill prey

0 400 800 1,200 km
0 400 800 miles



Martial eagle

This is the largest and most powerful eagle in Africa. A female may have a wingspan of 7 ft 7 in (2 m 30 cm). This eagle either swoops down from great heights at high speed to attack its prey or lies in wait to ambush prey from a branch. The martial eagle builds its nest in tall trees. Females usually lay just one egg.

VULTURES

Soaring above the African grasslands, white-backed vultures like these look out for dead animals to feed on. Their bare heads and necks allow them to feed without getting any feathers dirty. After a meal, vultures clean their feathers well to keep them in good condition for flying.

